CHAUSAR, CHAUPAR & PACHISI

From India’s cross-shaped race games to modern Ludo

A historical research dossier

Origins • Mahabharata traditions • Mughal court culture • Rules • Artefacts • Paintings • Colonial adaptations • Modern Ludo

Prepared 4 November 2026

Research note: this study distinguishes documented evidence from legend and later popular retellings. Dates attached to artworks and surviving objects refer to those objects, not necessarily to the invention of the game.

Contents and research approach

The dossier is organised as a sequence of focused chapters, from terminology and early evidence through Mughal court culture, surviving objects, colonial-era adaptations and digital Ludo. It includes a rules overview, a timeline, a glossary and a source trail for historical images.

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01. How to read this history

This study follows Chausar/Chaupar, Pachisi and Ludo as related members of a family of Indian cross-shaped race games. They are not interchangeable names in every historical source. Regional rules, equipment and naming vary. The central historical question is not simply “when was Ludo invented?” but how a family of games was played, represented, adapted and commercialised across different societies.

Evidence is separated into three levels: surviving objects and architecture; contemporary or near-contemporary written descriptions; and later stories or popular retellings. A board found in a museum can prove that a particular form existed by its documented date. It cannot automatically prove that the same game existed in the Vedic age.

02. Executive overview

Chausar (also written chaupar, chaupad or chausar) and Pachisi are traditional Indian race games played on a cruciform track. A common form uses four players, four counters per player, and cowrie shells or elongated dice to determine movement. Players race around the arms of the cross and bring their counters to the centre or home area. Ludo is a simplified, standardised descendant/adaptation popularised in Britain in the late nineteenth century.

The most secure evidence for the recognisable cruciform Chaupar/Pachisi family reaches back to around the fifteenth century, while older Indian dice games and race-game traditions certainly existed. The Mahabharata's dice match is an important cultural parallel, not proof of an identical board game.

03. Names and spellings

The names appear in multiple transliterations: caupa■/chaupar, chaupad, chausar, chopad, pachisi/pachisi, and regional names such as pagade or pagaday. Spellings shift with language, region and colonial transcription. “Pachisi” is commonly associated with the number twenty-five, traditionally connected with a notable throw or score in some versions; exact explanations differ across sources.

“Chaupar” and “Pachisi” are often grouped together in museum descriptions because they share a cross-shaped board and related play mechanics. Specialists caution that historical rules differed, and a bare board may not reveal which variant was played.

04. The game family, not one frozen rulebook

Traditional games were living practices. Boards could be embroidered on cloth, drawn on the ground, or permanently marked on a palace courtyard. Counters might be wood, ivory or other materials; throws could use cowries or oblong dice. A modern boxed game with fixed colours and rules should not be projected backwards onto every earlier version.

This matters when interpreting archaeological finds: a cross-shaped pattern can be suggestive, but without a securely associated set of counters, dice and textual explanation, its exact game identity may remain uncertain.

05. The oldest evidence: what can be claimed

A major scholarly reassessment by Jacob Schmidt-Madsen argues that the available evidence securely traces the cruciform game of Chaupar/Pachisi only to the fifteenth century. The article challenges the common assertion that the exact game is demonstrably ancient. Earlier games may have contributed elements, but continuity must be demonstrated rather than assumed.

This is the most responsible answer to “what is the oldest Chausar?”: there is no universally agreed single oldest surviving complete set. The earliest secure historical horizon for the recognisable game is late medieval/early modern India, with clearer descriptions and objects from the Mughal and later periods.

06. Earlier Indian dice games

Dice play in South Asia predates the securely documented cross-shaped Pachisi board. The Vedic corpus contains references to gambling with dice, and the Mahabharata makes a dice contest central to its narrative. These references establish the cultural importance of gaming and wagering, but do not describe the later cruciform board, its track, or its four-colour counters.

Earlier board-game traditions are also suggested by archaeological finds from the Indus civilisation. Yet identifying the exact rules of a game from isolated boards, pieces or marked surfaces is difficult. The safest account distinguishes the long history of gaming from the later documented history of Pachisi.

07. The Mahabharata dice episode

In the Mahabharata, Yudhishthira is drawn into a game of dice with Shakuni, who plays on behalf of the Kauravas. The stakes escalate from wealth and kingdom to the brothers and Draupadi. Yudhishthira loses, setting in motion the humiliation of Draupadi and the Pandavas' exile. The episode explores dharma, royal duty, addiction, manipulation and the destructive power of a rigged contest.

The story is often linked popularly to Chausar. That connection is culturally powerful, but the epic describes a dice wager, not a sufficiently detailed cross-shaped Pachisi board. It should therefore be presented as a related dice-game tradition, not as a documented match of modern Chausar.

08. Shakuni and the loaded-dice tradition

Popular retellings often say Shakuni used magical or loaded dice, sometimes claiming they were made from the bones of a relative. Such details vary among later tellings and should not be presented as a single universally attested passage of the epic. The central narrative point is that Shakuni's skill and manipulation make the game profoundly unequal.

For a history of Chausar, the episode is valuable because it shows how dice play could symbolise political risk and moral collapse. It does not establish the precise rules of Pachisi or Ludo.

09. Dice, chance and royal power

Dice games can dramatise uncertainty: a ruler may possess armies and wealth yet surrender control through a throw. In epic literature, gambling becomes a metaphor for temptation and the failure of judgement. In courtly settings, games could also serve as recreation, sociability and displays of status.

Chausar’s combination of chance and tactical movement made it suitable for extended play. Players had to interpret throws, choose which counter to move and decide when to expose a piece to capture. It was not merely a passive lottery.

10. The 12th-century M■nasoll■sa and precursors

The twelfth-century Sanskrit encyclopaedic work M■nasoll■sa includes descriptions of games, including phañjik■, which scholars have considered when tracing earlier ludic elements. The relationship between phañjik■ and later Chaupar/Pachisi is a question of possible antecedents, not a proven straight line of descent.

This is a useful example of how game history works: similar mechanics may appear in different games, and a later game can inherit or recombine older ideas without being identical to them.

11. The fifteenth-century horizon

The fifteenth century is important because specialist research identifies it as the earliest period to which the recognisable cruciform Chaupar/Pachisi can currently be securely traced. The evidence base is not a single “birth certificate”; it is a reconstruction from texts, objects and later descriptions.

The game may be older than its surviving evidence. However, historians cannot convert probability into certainty. A careful account says that the game is securely visible by this period, while allowing that its origins may reach further back.

12. The Mughal world

Under the Mughals, Chaupar/Pachisi became associated with courtly leisure. The game's cross-shaped layout, coloured teams and dice made it visually legible in a palace setting. It could be played on portable textile boards or represented at monumental scale in architecture.

Mughal court culture preserved detailed descriptions of recreation, ceremonies and imperial life. The writings of Abu'l-Fazl, Akbar's court intellectual and biographer, are especially important for understanding games and the emperor's interests.

13. Akbar and the Pachisi courtyard

At Fatehpur Sikri, Akbar's sixteenth-century imperial complex contains a courtyard conventionally known as the Pachisi Court. Its paving is laid out in a large grid associated with the game. The court is a remarkable architectural witness to the status of board games in the imperial environment.

The court is often dated to Akbar's building programme at Fatehpur Sikri, principally 1571–1585. It is a monumental playing surface, not a surviving portable board. The site is among the most compelling physical landmarks in the history of the game.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution's catalogue.

14. Did Akbar use living human pieces?

A famous story says that Akbar used women of the court, often described as courtesans or enslaved women, as life-sized playing pieces who moved across the courtyard. The story appears in popular histories and tourism narratives. Sahapedia discusses it as a legend associated with the site, while other historians have questioned the certainty of the claim.

The responsible conclusion is that the courtyard is real and its association with Pachisi is well established; the precise practice of using living people as counters is less securely documented. This report treats it as a reported tradition, not an uncontested fact.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution's catalogue.

15. Abu’l-Fazl and the rules

Abu’l-Fazl’s account is central to descriptions of the game at Akbar’s court. The game is described with a cross-shaped board, sixteen pieces and three dice in one account of Chaupar. Other forms use cowrie shells or two oblong dice. This variation is important: historical play did not have one universal equipment specification.

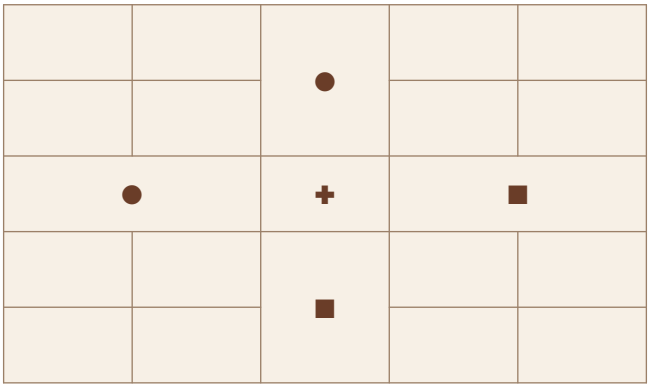
The game commonly involved four players, each with four pieces. Teams or partnerships could be formed by players sitting opposite one another. Counters moved around the arms of the cross and sought to complete a circuit and enter the central home.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

16. How the traditional board is laid out

The classic board is cruciform: four arms meet at a central square. Each arm contains a series of marked spaces. The route is arranged so that players enter from their own starting area, travel around the track, and eventually turn inward toward the centre. Some boards include decorative central motifs and special safe squares.

Cloth boards are especially important because they could be folded, carried and stored. Embroidery also transformed the board into a textile artwork. The design was therefore both functional and decorative.



Simplified cross-shaped concept diagram; not a scale-accurate rule board.

17. Players, teams and counters

A common form accommodates four players, each controlling four counters, for sixteen pieces in total. In partnership play, opposite players cooperate. Counters may be differentiated by colour, material or pattern. Museum examples show how elaborate the pieces could become: carved ivory, painted pigment, lacquer and turned wood all appear in surviving sets.

The number and appearance of counters vary by region and rule set. A modern Ludo set’s four colours and four tokens per player reflect a simplified standardisation, not every historical variant.

18. Cowrie shells and oblong dice

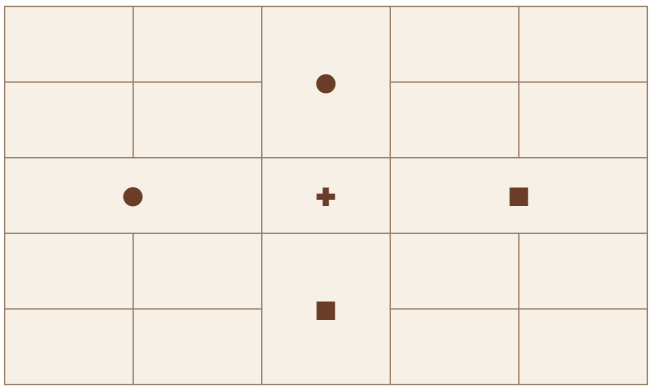
Traditional Pachisi may use cowrie shells as casting pieces. The number landing with the opening upward determines a move according to the local scoring table. Chaupar is also associated with elongated, four-sided dice known as pasa. These are unlike the familiar cubic die used in most modern Ludo sets.

Because scoring tables vary, a throw’s value cannot be stated as universal. Some versions award extra turns for particular throws; some use specific counts to enter a piece or continue movement. Rules should always be attributed to a particular regional form.

19. A practical rules overview

A common four-player version begins with each player’s four counters in a home area. Players take turns casting cowries or dice. A qualifying throw allows a counter to enter the track. Counters move along a fixed route, usually around the cross and toward the central home. Landing on an opponent’s unprotected counter may send it back to its starting area.

Safe squares protect counters from capture. A player wins by bringing all their counters home. Exact entry throws, scoring, bonus turns, capture rules and partnership arrangements differ by tradition. This is a family resemblance, not a single standard rulebook.



Simplified cross-shaped concept diagram; not a scale-accurate rule board.

20. Captures, safety and strategy

The threat of capture gives the race game its tactical dimension. A player may advance a counter toward home, move a vulnerable counter out of danger, or use a throw to capture an opponent. Safe spaces create temporary refuges. In partnership play, one player may sometimes help the other by occupying strategic squares or coordinating movement.

The game mixes luck and choice. Throws are random, but players choose which piece to move and how to balance speed against safety. This helps explain its enduring appeal across ages and social settings.

21. Why people played

Games serve many purposes: amusement, sociability, competition, gambling, teaching, ritual and status display. Chausar/Pachisi could be an intimate family pastime, a public leisure activity or a courtly spectacle. Fine boards and counters made the game an object of craft and prestige.

It is tempting to assign one universal purpose, such as military training or religious instruction. Evidence does not justify that for all forms of Chausar. Its most securely visible roles include recreation and, in some contexts, wagering and court entertainment.

22. Gender and social life

The game appears in contexts that cross social boundaries. Courtly objects and accounts point to elite play; colonial-era paintings and later ethnographic documentation show ordinary people playing on the ground or on cloth boards. Women’s participation is sometimes visible in courtly stories and images, although the historical record is uneven.

A careful social history avoids assuming that a surviving royal object represents everyday play. Expensive ivory pieces tell us about elite craft; simple cloth boards and cowries better suggest portable, accessible forms.

23. The 18th-century object record

The Ashmolean Museum holds Chaupar playing pieces dated to the second half of the eighteenth century, associated with western India, possibly a Rajasthan court. The sixteen-piece set is carved from ivory and painted or lacquered. Some pieces show courtly scenes, including figures on horseback, elephants, camels or chariots.

These objects demonstrate that the counters themselves could be miniature works of art. They also show why a game’s material culture matters: the counters reveal regional craft, status and visual imagination beyond the rules.

24. The British Museum velvet Pachisi board

The British Museum’s velvet Pachisi board is dated broadly to 1800–1899 and was collected in Sri Lanka by Hugh Nevill, who worked in the colonial administration there from 1869 to 1886. The board is embroidered on velvet with silk and metallic thread and measures approximately 51 by 49 centimetres.

The object is a valuable example of textile-based play. Its catalogue record also illustrates the movement of Indian games and objects through colonial collecting networks. A museum acquisition location is not necessarily the place where an object was originally made.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

25. The V&A embroidered board

The Victoria and Albert Museum catalogue includes a Pachisi board with a cross-shaped playing area and rich textile decoration. The object is a reminder that game boards were not merely diagrams: they could display embroidery, colour, regional design and skilled labour. A cloth board could be rolled or folded and used in domestic settings.

When studying a museum object, its catalogue date, place of manufacture, acquisition history and materials should be kept separate. “Collected in” does not automatically mean “made in.”

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

26. The 1851 painting and its date

An archival image titled “1851 Indian men playing a game of pachisi” shows four men seated around a cross-shaped board. The image is attributed to William Carpenter in the relevant collection record. Its title and catalogue context are useful evidence for nineteenth-century visual documentation of the game.

The date should be quoted as the date given by the archive or artwork record, not casually converted into a claim that the game itself began in 1851. A painting is evidence of representation and practice at a moment, not proof of origin.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

27. Rajas and courtiers playing Chaupar

A painting offered by Christie’s is catalogued as a Raja and his courtiers playing Chaupar, from the Punjab Hills, Guler or Basohli region, circa 1720–1750. It depicts elite men gathered around a cross-shaped board. The image is significant because it records the game as a courtly social activity.

Auction catalogues can provide useful object descriptions and provenance, but their claims should be cross-checked with museum or scholarly sources where possible. The painting’s approximate date is not a date for the invention of Chaupar.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

28. Photographs of the Pachisi Court

A photograph of the Pachisi Court at Fatehpur Sikri helps distinguish the surviving architectural site from later illustrations of Akbar playing. The court is a physical monument; the familiar scene of the emperor directing living counters is a reconstructed or retold narrative.

A late nineteenth-century photograph of the court and the modern photographs available online are different kinds of evidence. The former documents the site at a historical moment; the latter record its present condition and help visitors understand its layout.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

29. Colonial encounters and collecting

During the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, European travellers, administrators and scholars described Indian games. Thomas Hyde’s De Ludis Orientalibus (1694) is an early European work on games from the East. Later writers and collectors documented boards, rules and terminology.

Colonial collecting also moved game objects into museums and private collections in Britain and elsewhere. This creates a rich archive, but it also means that provenance, collecting circumstances and cataloguing language deserve scrutiny.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

30. Thomas Hyde, 1694

Thomas Hyde’s De Ludis Orientalibus, published in 1694, is frequently cited in the European study of Asian games. It belongs to an early period of comparative scholarship, when European writers began recording rules and names of games from outside Europe.

Hyde’s work is not a modern ethnography, and its terminology may reflect the limits of the author’s sources. Still, it is a landmark in the written reception of Indian board games in Europe.

31. The road to Ludo

The British game Ludo is a simplified adaptation of the Indian Pachisi family. The National Archives' educational material states that Ludo came to Britain in 1891 and was patented by Alfred Collier. The simplification made the game easier to manufacture and explain to a mass market.

Ludo standardised the cross-shaped race track into a compact printed board, used cubic dice and reduced the complexity of traditional scoring. Its commercial success helped make it a familiar family game.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution's catalogue.

32. The 1891 patent and Alfred Collier

The National Archives identifies 1891 as the year Ludo came to Britain and associates its patent with Alfred Collier. This late Victorian moment is a key point in the transition from a diverse family of Indian games to a mass-produced commercial format.

The patent history should be distinguished from the much older history of Pachisi. Collier did not invent the Indian game; the British adaptation reorganised and simplified an existing tradition for a new market.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

33. How Ludo changed the rules

Compared with traditional Chaupar/Pachisi, modern Ludo typically uses a square printed board, a single six-sided die, four colours and four tokens per player. Players move from a coloured yard onto a shared loop and then up a private home column. A six commonly allows entry from the yard and an extra turn, although house rules vary.

The simplified system removes the traditional cowrie scoring tables and the use of oblong dice. It also standardises the route and safe squares. The result is faster to learn and easier to mass-produce.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

34. Ludo and Parcheesi

Parcheesi is an American commercial adaptation of Pachisi, while Ludo is the British adaptation. Both preserve the race-game structure but have their own rule histories and commercial identities. The names are related through the broader Indian source tradition, but the games should not be treated as identical in every rule detail.

Commercial versions changed the board, dice, tokens, branding and target audience. These adaptations are part of the game’s global history, not merely footnotes.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

35. Global spread and popular culture

In the twentieth century, Ludo became a household game in many countries. Its compact rules and low equipment cost suited family play, schools and social gatherings. Local names and house rules proliferated. Digital versions later moved the game from the tabletop to mobile phones and online multiplayer platforms.

The global success of Ludo is an example of cultural translation: a game travels, is simplified and repackaged, and then becomes familiar in settings far from its earlier courtly and domestic contexts.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

36. Modern digital Ludo

Digital Ludo reproduces the familiar turn-based race, often adding online matchmaking, chat, rankings, animations and timed turns. The basic loop remains recognisable: roll, choose a token, race, capture and reach home. Mobile play has expanded access but can also change the social experience through remote play and monetised features.

Digital versions are not neutral copies. Their rules, matchmaking, rewards and interface design influence how people play. The history therefore continues beyond the printed board.

37. Regional variations in India

Indian forms vary in board size, route, scoring, dice, cowrie counts, safe squares, team structure and terminology. Cloth boards and locally made counters are important in many traditions. Some variants are played by two, three or four participants; others use partnerships.

A regional rulebook should identify the community and locality it describes. Avoid presenting one version as “the original Indian rules.” The game’s diversity is part of its history.

38. Craft traditions: cloth, wood and ivory

Boards could be stitched, embroidered, painted or marked on the ground. Counters could be turned from wood, carved from ivory, stained with pigments or made from readily available materials. The contrast between a palace set and a household board reveals how the same game could inhabit different economic worlds.

Ivory objects must also be interpreted in their historical context and with contemporary ethical awareness. Museum collections preserve craft histories, but modern production should not encourage trade in protected wildlife materials.

39. The game as art and image

Paintings of Chaupar players are not simply illustrations of rules. They show posture, clothing, social hierarchy, architecture and the place of leisure in courtly life. Embroidered boards reveal the meeting of utility and decorative art. Miniature counters can carry scenes of animals, riders and courtly figures.

Art-historical interpretation asks who commissioned an image, where it was made, what audience saw it and whether it depicts a real event or an idealised scene. These questions prevent a painting from being misread as a photograph.

40. Comparing Chausar, Pachisi and Ludo

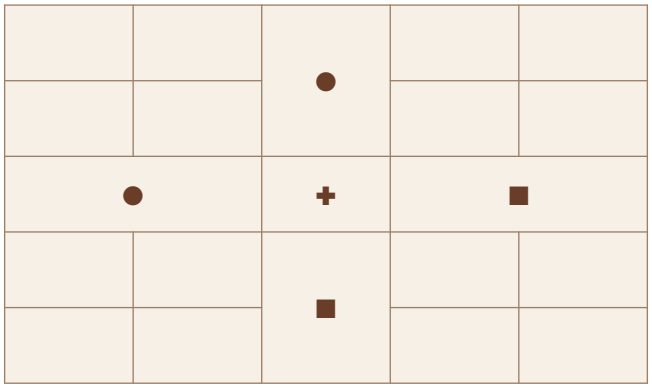
Chausar/Chaupar and Pachisi share a related cross-shaped race-game structure, but the names can refer to distinct rule traditions. Ludo is a later simplified commercial adaptation. The differences are visible in equipment, scoring, board layout and the complexity of movement.

A useful comparison is therefore genealogical rather than absolute: Ludo belongs to the family shaped by Pachisi, while Chaupar and Pachisi are closely related Indian forms with overlapping histories. A single straight-line story would erase regional variation.

41. A sample traditional turn

Imagine a four-player game using cowries. A player casts the shells and consults the local scoring table. If the result permits entry or movement, the player chooses one counter and advances it along the prescribed route. If the counter lands on an opponent outside a safe square, it may capture that counter. The captured piece returns to its starting position.

This is a simplified teaching example. Actual rules differ, especially in how throws are scored, how counters enter, and whether a player receives bonus turns.

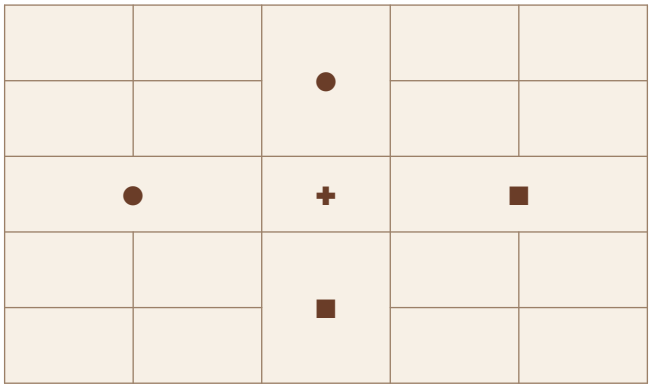


Simplified cross-shaped concept diagram; not a scale-accurate rule board.

42. A sample modern Ludo turn

In standard modern Ludo, a player rolls one cubic die. A six may allow a token to leave the yard. The player then moves a token the number of spaces shown, following the shared track. Landing on an opponent’s token on an ordinary square usually sends it home; safe squares protect tokens. Once a token completes the loop, it enters its colour’s home column.

The first player to bring all four tokens into the final home space wins. Editions and house rules vary, particularly around entry, bonus turns and blockades.



Simplified cross-shaped concept diagram; not a scale-accurate rule board.

43. Timeline: key milestones

Before the fifteenth century: dice games and related race-game elements are present in South Asian traditions, but the exact later cross-shaped game is not securely demonstrated. Twelfth century: M■nasoll■sa describes games including phañjik■, considered a possible antecedent. Fifteenth century: earliest secure horizon for the cruciform Chaupar/Pachisi according to modern specialist research. Sixteenth century: Mughal court descriptions and Akbar’s Fatehpur Sikri Pachisi Court. 1694: Thomas Hyde publishes De Ludis Orientalibus. Eighteenth century: surviving elite counters and court paintings. Nineteenth century: textile boards, colonial descriptions and paintings. 1891: Ludo introduced/patented in Britain by Alfred Collier. Twentieth century onward: global mass-market and digital Ludo.

44. What the evidence cannot tell us

The exact inventor of Chausar is unknown. No reliable evidence identifies one person, one court or one year as the moment of invention. A cross-shaped board found without associated equipment may not be securely identified. The Mahabharata dice episode cannot be equated automatically with Pachisi. The living-piece story at Fatehpur Sikri is not equally secure as the courtyard itself.

These limits do not make the history less interesting. They show how responsible historical research distinguishes what is known, what is plausible and what remains legend.

45. Common myths and corrections

Myth: Ludo was invented in ancient India under that name. Correction: Ludo is a late nineteenth-century British adaptation of Pachisi. Myth: the Mahabharata explicitly describes the modern cross-shaped Chausar board. Correction: it describes a dice contest, not enough board detail to identify Pachisi. Myth: Akbar’s living counters are certain fact. Correction: the courtyard is real; the human-piece story is debated. Myth: all Chaupar and Pachisi boards follow one rulebook. Correction: regional variants are substantial.

46. How to identify a credible historical image

Check the institution or collection holding the image, its catalogue title, date, material, dimensions, provenance and rights statement. Separate the date of the depicted event from the date of the artwork. A 1915 print showing Akbar in 1575 is an image published in 1915, not a sixteenth-century eyewitness painting.

Prefer museum collections, national archives, university repositories and scholarly publications. Commercial image sites can help locate works, but should not be the sole authority for historical claims.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

47. Suggested museum and archive trail

Useful collections include the Victoria and Albert Museum, the British Museum, the Ashmolean Museum, the Indian Heritage Centre in Singapore, the Ancient Indian Boardgames digital archive and the National Archives (UK). These institutions provide object records, dates, materials, acquisition details and educational interpretation.

When using their images in a public project, follow each institution’s image licensing and reproduction terms. A link to a collection record is not the same as permission to republish a high-resolution image.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

48. The cultural afterlife of the game

Chausar and Pachisi persist as more than a set of moves. They are associated with epic storytelling, courtly leisure, textile traditions, colonial collecting, family play and modern entertainment. The same basic tension between chance and choice links a cowrie throw on a cloth board to a six rolled on a phone screen.

The game’s history is therefore a history of adaptation. Communities preserved familiar mechanics while changing materials, rules, names and meanings.

> Visual archive to consult: see the linked museum and archival records in the final reference chapters. Captions and dates should be taken from the holding institution’s catalogue.

49. Conclusion

The most defensible history places the recognisable cruciform Chaupar/Pachisi within the late-medieval and early-modern Indian world, with especially rich evidence under the Mughals. Earlier dice traditions and literary narratives, including the Mahabharata, form an important cultural background but do not prove that the exact later board game existed in epic times. Akbar’s Pachisi Court, museum-held counters and boards, and eighteenth- and nineteenth-century paintings provide tangible evidence. In 1891, Alfred Collier’s British Ludo adaptation simplified the game for mass play. Modern Ludo is thus not a disconnected invention: it is one global descendant of a diverse Indian game family.

50. Glossary

Chaupar/Chaupad: Indian cross-shaped race-game tradition. Chausar: common variant spelling. Pachisi: closely related Indian race game, often associated with a score of twenty-five. Pasa: elongated Indian dice. Cowries: shells used as casting pieces. Counter/token: playing piece moved along the track. Cruciform: shaped like a cross. Safe square: a protected space where a counter cannot be captured. Home/centre: the destination area. Phanjik■: an earlier game mentioned in M■nasoll■sa and discussed as a possible antecedent.

51. Research bibliography and source notes

Jacob Schmidt-Madsen, “The Crux of the Cruciform: Retracing the Early History of Chaupar and Pachisi,” Board Game Studies Journal 15 (2021), pp. 29–77. DOI: 10.2478/bgs-2021-0003. MAP Academy, “Pachisi.” Sahapedia, “Towards a Cultural History of Indian Board Games: Backgammon, Chaupar and Chaturanga.” Ashmolean Museum, “Pieces for the game of chaupar,” dated second half of the eighteenth century. British Museum/Google Arts & Culture, “Velvet Pachisi game board,” 1800–1899. V&A Collections, “Pachisi board.” National Archives (UK), “What can we learn from old board games?”

52. Primary visual references and collection links

Victoria and Albert Museum, Pachisi board: https://collections.vam.ac.uk/item/O452950/pachisi-board-pachisi-board-unknown/ . Ashmolean Museum, Chaupar pieces: https://jameelcentre.ashmolean.org/collection/921/object/13240 . British Museum velvet Pachisi board record: https://artsandculture.google.com/asset/velvet-pachisi-game-board/vQHGssW2nMPv3Q . Christie’s, Raja and courtiers playing Chaupar, circa 1720–1750: https://www.christies.com/en/lot/lot-6417048 . Wikimedia Commons, 1851 Indian men playing Pachisi: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:1851_Indian_men_playing_a_game_of_pachisi.jpg . Fatehpur Sikri court photograph: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:The_pachisi_court.JPG .

53. Further reading and verification

MAP Academy’s Pachisi entry is especially useful for correcting claims about the Mahabharata and the earliest surviving evidence. The 2021 Schmidt-Madsen article provides the specialist argument for a fifteenth-century secure horizon. Sahapedia offers a broader cultural history and discussion of Akbar’s court. The National Archives provides the 1891 Ludo/Alfred Collier account. Museum object records should be consulted directly before reproducing object images or quoting dimensions and dates.

Illustrated source register

Image / object	Date / significance	Collection or source
Embroidered Pachisi board	V&A catalogue object; textile board	https://collections.vam.ac.uk/item/O452950/pachisi-board-pachisi-board-unknown/
Men playing Pachisi	Archival image titled 1851	https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:1851_Indian_men_playing_a_game_of_pachisi.jpg
Chaupar ivory counters	Ashmolean; second half of 18th c.	https://jameelcentre.ashmolean.org/collection/921/object/13240
Velvet Pachisi board	British Museum; 19th c.	https://artsandculture.google.com/asset/velvet-pachisi-game-board/vQHGssW2nMPv3Q
Raja and courtiers playing Chaupar	Punjab Hills; c.1720–1750	https://www.christies.com/en/lot/lot-6417048
Pachisi Court, Fatehpur Sikri	Monumental court associated with Akbar	https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:The_pachisi_court.JPG
Akbar playing with living pieces	Later historical illustration, published 1915	https://www.bridgemanimages.com/en/dudley-robert/akbar-playing-pachisi-or-chaupur-with-live-pieces-at-fatehpur-sikri-in-1575-from-hutchinson-s/nomedium/asset/3588308

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Selected bibliography

• Schmidt-Madsen, Jacob. “The Crux of the Cruciform: Retracing the Early History of Chaupar and Pachisi.” Board Game Studies Journal 15 (2021), 29–77. https://doi.org/10.2478/bgs-2021-0003

• MAP Academy. “Pachisi.” https://imp-art.org/articles/pachisi/

• Sahapedia. Mohit Srivastava, “Towards a Cultural History of Indian Board Games: Backgammon, Chaupar and Chaturanga.” https://www.sahapedia.org/towards-cultural-history-indian-board-games-backgammon-chaupar-and-chaturanga

• Ashmolean Museum. “Pieces for the game of chaupar.” Collection record, second half of the 18th century. https://jameelcentre.ashmolean.org/collection/921/object/13240

• National Archives (UK). “What can we learn from old board games?” https://www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/education/teaching-resources/what-can-we-learn-from-old-board-games/

• Indian Heritage Centre, Singapore. “Collection of Gaming Pieces and Dice,” 18th–19th century. https://www.roots.gov.sg/Collection-Landing/listing/1321154

• Ancient Indian Boardgames: Digital Documentation. “Chaupar, Pataleshwar.” https://www.indiaboardgamesarchive.in/omekas/s/ancientindianboardgames/item/76

• Victoria and Albert Museum. “Pachisi board.” https://collections.vam.ac.uk/item/O452950/pachisi-board-pachisi-board-unknown/

• British Museum / Google Arts & Culture. “Velvet Pachisi game board.” https://artsandculture.google.com/asset/velvet-pachisi-game-board/vQHGssW2nMPv3Q

• MAP Academy and museum object records should be read alongside specialist scholarship; popular retellings of the Akbar story should not replace primary evidence.

Methodological conclusion

The evidence supports a long South Asian history of dice play and a later, securely documented history of the cruciform Chaupar/Pachisi family. The Mughal period provides unusually rich architectural and textual evidence. The nineteenth-century object and image record makes the game’s material culture visible, while the 1891 British Ludo adaptation explains the transition to the familiar modern board. The history is best understood as continuity through adaptation—not as a single invention story.